Self-drive itinerary · New Zealand · South Island

Christchurch to Queenstown by way of the glaciers, the Alps and Fiordland

Saturday 6 March to Sunday 14 March 2027 · 8 nights · 2 travellers · 1 driver

Arrive Christchurch Airport (CHC), Sat 6 Mar 2027, 14:30 (booked)

Depart Queenstown Airport (ZQN), Sun 14 Mar 2027, 11:00 (booked)

Route Arthur's Pass · West Coast glaciers · Haast Pass · Wānaka · Aoraki/Mount Cook · Tekapo · Queenstown · Glenorchy · Te Anau · Milford Road

Driving About 2,090 km in total. The longest day is 429 km, under your 500 km limit. Every day ends at least 2 hours before sunset.

Lens Mountains and lookouts, lakes, glaciers, wildlife. No boats or ferries, no beaches, no walks over about 2 hours.

Hotels Accor for 4 of 8 nights (every overnight town where Accor has a hotel). The other 4 are in towns with no Accor property. Every room has two beds and is aimed at NZ$300 a night or less.

Prepared 9 November 2026. Nothing in this plan has been booked or contacted on your behalf: every reservation below is an action for you to take. Prices and opening hours were checked by live web search in November 2026 where noted; items marked † come from planner knowledge after the live-search allowance ran out and must be checked before you rely on them.

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1. Trip overview

What this trip is for. You asked to see as much as possible of the South Island's mountains, lakes, glaciers and wildlife in eight nights. Early starts are fine, but there are hard rules: one driver, no more than 500 km a day, no driving after dark, no boats, no beaches, and no walks over about two hours. The shape below gets you onto all three of the South Island's great alpine roads (Arthur's Pass, Haast Pass and the Milford Road). You also get close to two glaciers on the West Coast and to New Zealand's highest mountain at Aoraki/Mount Cook. There are four chances to see kiwi, plus wild kea and takahē, and a lot of glacial lakes: Matheson, Wānaka, Hāwea, Pūkaki, Tekapo, Wakatipu, Te Anau, Gunn and the Mirror Lakes.

How it feels. Each day has one signature anchor and a named backup. The hard driving is front-loaded into two long days (Day 2 and Day 8), each broken into short legs with something worth stopping for every 60 to 90 minutes. The other driving days are 260 to 340 km. Every day ends in daylight with time to rest, because one driver doing 2,000 km is the real limiting factor on this trip. A tired driver costs more than a missed lookout.

> **The one thoughtful extra:** on Wednesday night at Tekapo you'll stand on the summit of Mount John inside the Aoraki Mackenzie International Dark Sky Reserve. The Dark Sky Project runs it by coach from the village, so you won't break the no-driving-after-dark rule. Mountains by day and the southern sky by night is the one evening worth staying up late for.

2. What I heard, and the assumptions I made

Echo-back. Two adults on a one-way self-drive from Christchurch to Queenstown. You land at CHC at 14:30 on Sat 6 March 2027 and fly out of ZQN at 11:00 on Sun 14 March 2027, which gives 8 nights. Only one person drives, on a full Australian licence printed in English. You'd like Accor hotels (you are ALL members) wherever possible, otherwise anything decent, always a room with two beds, at up to NZ$300 a night. The rules are a maximum of 500 km a day and never driving after dark. You want to see as much as possible and are happy with early starts. You love mountains and lookouts, lakes, glaciers and wildlife. You want to avoid any boat or ferry (one of you gets badly seasick), beaches, and walks longer than about 2 hours. The last day is only for returning the car and flying. Only the flights are booked. The scope is the New Zealand driving part only.

Assumptions (questions you didn't answer)

Topic	Assumption I planned on	If it's wrong
Nationality / passports	Both of you are Australian citizens travelling on Australian passports. The Australian licence and the cross-Tasman flights point that way.	Other passports may need an NZeTA (plus the International Visitor Conservation and Tourism Levy) applied for well before travel. See section 6.
Outbound flight on 14 Mar	The 11:00 ZQN departure is an international flight to Australia, so the car goes back by 08:00 (3 hours before).	If it's domestic, you can return the car at 09:00 instead.
Ages, mobility, diet	Healthy adults comfortable on easy 1 to 2 hour walks with some steps. No dietary restrictions.	Tell the restaurants when you book. Every walk has a shorter version listed.
Overall budget	Only the hotel cap (NZ$300/night) was given. Everything else is estimated in section 13 at a comfortable mid-range level.	The heli flight and the stargazing tour are the two big optional costs.
Vehicle	A standard 2WD rental car (compact SUV or mid-size sedan), not a campervan. One-way pick-up at CHC and drop-off at ZQN.	A campervan would need different overnight stops and slower drive times.
Helicopter and gondola	These are not boats, so I have included them as options. Motion sensitivity is real, though, so both are marked as optional with a ground-level backup.	Drop them. Every day still works without them.
"See as much as possible" vs pacing	One anchor per block, a rest block every day, and arrivals at least 2 hours before sunset.	Optional stops are listed so you can add more if energy allows.

Where I pushed back on myself, and on the brief

- **Day 1 has no anchor.** Coming from Australia the time difference is only about 2 hours, so jet lag is mild. Still, you'll have been up early, cleared biosecurity and picked up a car you've never driven. Day 1 is a short, optional kiwi stroll near the airport, not sightseeing.
- **The famous Hooker Valley Track is about 3 hours return**, which breaks your 2-hour rule. I've cut it at the second swing bridge (about 45 minutes each way per DOC), which keeps the best Aoraki views.
- **Milford Sound without a cruise.** For most visitors the boat is the point, but for you the 120 km road is the attraction. It has lakes, an alpine tunnel, kea, waterfalls and the Chasm, and from the foreshore you still get the classic view of Mitre Peak. You lose nothing you were going to enjoy.
- **Accor vs the route.** I could add a fifth Accor night by sleeping in Queenstown instead of Wānaka on Day 4. That would mean about 200 km of extra, repeated driving over Days 4 to 6 and the loss of the Mt Iron and Lake Wānaka evening. I don't recommend it (see section 3), but it's your call.
- **One driver, about 2,090 km.** That's more than most people drive in 8 days. I've kept it because you asked for maximum coverage, but there are firm rules: a 15-minute stop at least every 2 hours (the schedule has one every 60 to 90 minutes), no driving after a late night, and the passenger handles navigation and photos.

3. Route choice: three shapes, one recommendation

Option	What it is	You gain	You give up
A. The Alpine Grand Loop (RECOMMENDED)	CHC → Arthur's Pass → Hokitika → Franz Josef (2 nights) → Haast Pass → Wānaka → Aoraki/Mt Cook → Tekapo → Queenstown → Glenorchy → Te Anau → Milford Road → Queenstown. About 2,090 km, max 429 km/day.	All four of your interests at full strength: walk-up glaciers on the West Coast, all three alpine passes, Aoraki, the Mackenzie lakes, Fiordland. Two nights at Franz Josef give a weather buffer for the glacier flight.	Two long driving days (Days 2 and 8). 4 Accor nights rather than 5 or 6.
B. Inland Direct	CHC → Tekapo → Aoraki/Mt Cook → Wānaka → Queenstown → Te Anau/Milford → Queenstown. About 1,300 km.	Easier days. Possibly 5 Accor nights (Tekapo plus several Queenstown nights).	No West Coast, so the only glacier is the Tasman's grey terminal lake. No Arthur's Pass kea, no Haast Pass waterfalls, no Lake Matheson. Weakest for your glacier interest.
C. Glaciers, no Fiordland	Option A, but finishing with 3 nights in Queenstown and skipping Te Anau and the Milford Road.	One more Accor night and about 400 km less driving.	The Milford Road, which is arguably the most spectacular mountain drive in the country and a perfect fit for "mountains, lakes, wildlife, no boats".

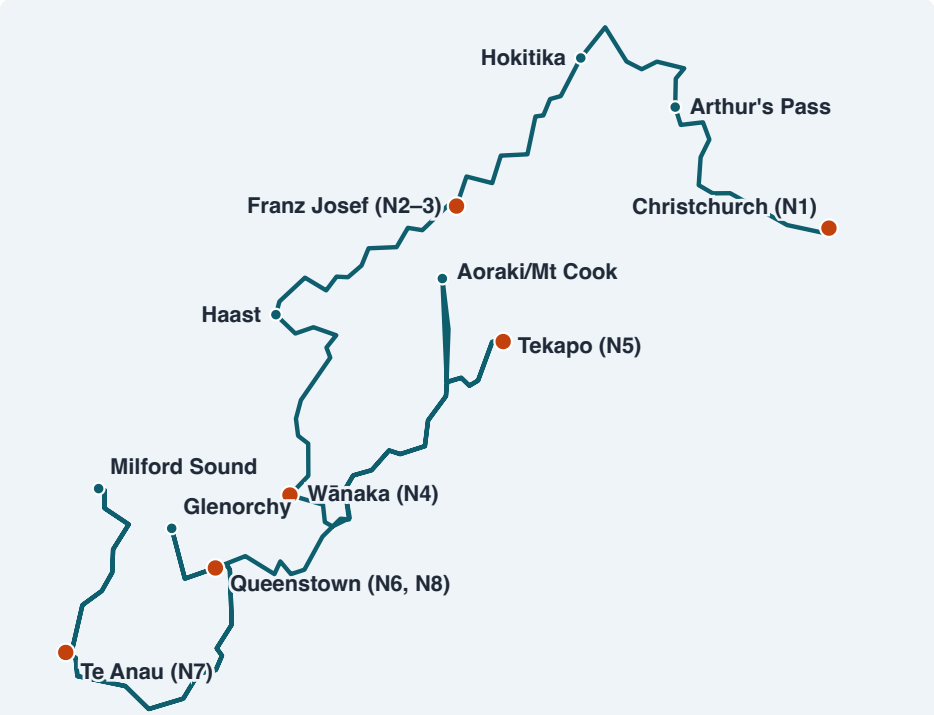
Why A. Your interest list reads like a description of the West Coast plus Fiordland. Glaciers are the deciding interest: Franz Josef and Fox are the only places where the ice comes down near rainforest and road level, and on a wet coast the second night is your insurance for clear-sky views. Option B saves a lot of driving but cuts out a third of what you said you wanted. Option C is the sensible fallback if the driver wants an easier final two days. In that case, drop Day 7 to 8 as written and use the alternative in Day 7's backup.

The Accor arithmetic, out loud

I checked Accor's own ALL listings in November 2026. Accor has hotels in **Christchurch** (Novotel Christchurch Airport, Peppers Clearwater), **Lake Tekapo** (Peppers Bluewater Resort, Mantra Lake Tekapo) and **Queenstown** (Novotel Lakeside, Sofitel, Hotel St Moritz MGallery, Peppers Beacon, Mantra The Point, and Mercure Queenstown Resort, which Accor's site also labels Mövenpick). I found **no publicly bookable Accor hotel** in Franz Josef, Fox Glacier, Wānaka or Te Anau. The "Accor Vacation Club" units at Oakridge Wānaka are a members-only holiday club, not an ALL hotel booking. So the recommended route sleeps Accor in every overnight town where Accor exists: **4 of 8 nights** (Christchurch, Tekapo, Queenstown twice).

Rejected alternative: sleeping in Queenstown on Day 4 instead of Wānaka. Day 4 would grow from 286 to about 355 km (adding the Crown Range at the end of the day), Day 5 from 338 to about 390 km, and Day 6 would repeat the Lindis Pass and Queenstown approach. That's around 200 km of extra driving for one more Accor night, and you'd lose the Mt Iron lookout. Not worth it for a single driver.

4. Route map and driving summary



Route geometry: OpenStreetMap / OSRM. Orange = overnight stops. Schematic, not for navigation.

Day	Date	Drive	km	Wheel time*	Leave / arrive	Sunset (end of light)	Night
1	Sat 6 Mar	CHC airport ↔ Willowbank (optional)	17	0h30	16:10 / 18:10	20:08 (20:37)	Christchurch Airport Accor
2	Sun 7 Mar	CHC → Arthur's Pass → Hokitika Gorge → Franz Josef	429	6h10	07:15 / 18:00	20:16 (20:45)	Franz Josef
3	Mon 8 Mar	Lake Matheson, glacier valley, local	56	1h10	07:00 / 16:30	20:14 (20:43)	Franz Josef
4	Tue 9 Mar	Franz Josef → Haast Pass → Wānaka	286	3h50	08:15 / 14:45	20:17 (20:47)	Wānaka
5	Wed 10 Mar	Wānaka → Lindis Pass → Aoraki/Mt Cook → Tekapo	338	4h30	07:35 / 16:15	20:10 (20:39)	Lake Tekapo Accor
6	Thu 11 Mar	Mt John → Lindis Pass → Kawarau Gorge → Arrowtown → Queenstown	284	4h00	09:00 / 15:30	20:16 (20:45)	Queenstown Accor
7	Fri 12 Mar	Queenstown → Glenorchy → Queenstown → Te Anau	264	3h35	07:40 / 13:45	20:18 (20:48)	Te Anau
8	Sat 13 Mar	Te Anau → Milford Sound → Te Anau → Queenstown	407	5h35	07:30 / 17:15	20:12 (20:41)	Queenstown Accor
9	Sun 14 Mar	Hotel → Frankton fuel → ZQN car return	7	0h15	07:45 / 08:00	n/a	Fly 11:00

* Distances come from OpenStreetMap routing (OSRM) between the actual stops, queried 9 Nov 2026. Wheel time is moving time on sealed highway, rounded up. Allow about 25% more for roadworks, one-lane bridges and photo stops. Sunrise and sunset are calculated for each night's town using NZ Daylight Time (UTC+13), which runs until 4 April 2027. The figure in brackets is the end of civil twilight, i.e. when it is properly dark. **Driving window rule used throughout: no wheels turning before first light (about 30 minutes before sunrise) or after sunset, and every planned arrival at least 2 hours before sunset.** Sunrise on your driving days falls between 07:15 and 07:41, and sunset between 20:08 and 20:18 in the towns where you sleep.

5. Where you sleep

Rules applied: Accor first wherever it exists; a room with **two separate beds**; target NZ$300 per room per night or less. In November 2026 none of the hotel sites showed March 2027 prices, so the figures below are recent snapshots and ranges from the sites named in section 14. Book **now on free-cancellation (flexible) rates** and recheck prices in January. Where an Accor option might break the cap or has no true twin room, I give the next choice with the trade-off.

Night	Recommended	Why this one / room to book	Backup (and the trade-off)
N1 Sat 6 Mar Christchurch	Accor **Novotel Christchurch Airport**, 30 Durey Rd. About a 2-minute walk to the terminal (per Accor).	Book the **Superior Room with 2 Double Beds**, or the 3 Single Beds room. Sleeping at the airport puts you on SH73 toward Arthur's Pass at sunrise without crossing the city. Parking is in airport car parks at extra cost.	Accor Peppers Clearwater Resort (near the airport, quieter, golf-resort setting). Check that it has a two-bed room. A 10 to 15 minute drive away.
N2 to N3 Sun 7 and Mon 8 Mar Franz Josef	**Scenic Hotel Franz Josef Glacier** (no Accor in Glacier Country).	Book the **Superior Twin with 2 Queen beds**. It's in the village, walkable to restaurants and the heli bases, and its own **Canavans Restaurant** means no driving after dark. Recent snapshots averaged around NZ$140 to 200, well inside the cap.	Te Waonui Forest Retreat (more upmarket, probably over the cap). Or a twin room at any motel on Cron St. Keep it in the village so you can walk to dinner.
N4 Tue 9 Mar Wānaka	**Edgewater** (lakefront) if a twin is NZ$300 or less. Otherwise **Wanaka Hotel** (town centre).	Edgewater sits on the lake edge with Mt Aspiring views and has twin-bed rooms. Recent prices were mixed (about NZ$170 to 400), so book it only if a twin is quoted under the cap. Wanaka Hotel lists "1 Queen + 1 large twin" and "3 twin beds" rooms and is the cheaper, walk-everywhere choice.	Oakridge Resort (former Grand Mercure, 1.5 km from the lake). Accor no longer lists it on ALL as far as I could verify.
N5 Wed 10 Mar Lake Tekapo	Accor **Mantra Lake Tekapo**, 2-Bedroom Apartment (1 queen + 2 single beds), 1 Beauchamp Place.	This is the only Accor room in Tekapo with genuinely separate beds. It's about a 9-minute walk to the Church of the Good Shepherd and about 5 minutes to the lake. **Price risk:** recent quotes ranged from about NZ$300 to over NZ$600. Take it only if the ALL member rate is NZ$300 or less.	(a) Accor **Peppers Bluewater Resort**, 1-Bedroom Villa (king bed + single sofa bed). It's Accor and likely under the cap, but the second bed is a sofa bed. (b) Non-Accor **The Godley Hotel** on the lakefront: rooms with a queen plus a single bed, and recent prices well under the cap.
N6 Thu 11 Mar Queenstown	Accor **Novotel Queenstown Lakeside**, corner of Earl St and Marine Parade.	Book the **Standard Room with Two Double Beds**, or the Alpine-view version. You can walk to the Skyline gondola, Kiwi Park and the restaurants, so the car stays parked all evening. March is busy in Queenstown, so check that the rate is NZ$300 or less.	Accor **Mercure (Mövenpick) Queenstown Resort**, Fernhill, 5 minutes' drive, with lake views. Usually cheaper, but you'd need a taxi to get back after dark.
N7 Fri 12 Mar Te Anau	**Distinction Luxmore Hotel** (no Accor in Te Anau).	Book the **Deluxe Twin with 2 Queen beds**. It's central, close to Redcliff for dinner, and on the side of town where the Milford road starts. Mid-2026 snapshots were NZ$274 to 293, which is close to the cap, so book early.	Any Te Anau motel with a twin room on Te Anau Terrace (lake side), e.g. Kingsgate Hotel Te Anau†.

N8 Sat 13 Mar Queenstown	Accor **Novotel Queenstown Lakeside** again.	Ask for the same room type. It's 7 km and about 10 minutes to the airport for the 08:00 car return.	Same as N6.

For every Accor booking: add your ALL membership number, book the "member flexible" rate, ask in the booking note for "two separate beds, confirmed (twin share, two adults)", and request free on-site parking if they offer it. Expect 4 Accor nights (N1, N5, N6, N8). If Tekapo falls back to The Godley, that drops to 3. That's the price of insisting on two real beds within NZ$300, and I think it's the right trade.

6. Logistics scaffold

Entry (assuming Australian citizens)

- **No visa and no NZeTA** needed for Australian citizens on Australian passports (Immigration NZ). Australian *permanent residents* who aren't citizens do need an NZeTA but not the IVL.
- **New Zealand Traveller Declaration (NZTD)** is required for everyone, Australians included. Complete it online or in the app; secondary sources say within 24 hours before departure. Do it on **Fri 5 March 2027**.
- **Biosecurity:** declare all food, and clean hiking shoes before packing them. Soil on boots is a classic fine at Christchurch.
- **Passport:** it must be valid for your stay. Check expiry dates now in case renewal is needed.

Driving licence and rental car

- A current, full Australian licence is valid in New Zealand for up to 12 months, and no IDP is needed because it's in English. Take the **physical card**: several major rental companies don't accept digital licences. Many renters require the licence to have been held for 12 months or more.
- NZ drives on the left, like Australia. The differences that catch Australians out: many **one-lane bridges** on the West Coast and Haast Pass (give way to the side the sign tells you to), **traffic lights at the Homer Tunnel**, and NZ's give-way rules at intersections.
- **One-way fee** CHC to ZQN: anywhere from zero to several hundred dollars depending on the company. It's often low on this direction. Compare GO Rentals, Europcar, Avis/Budget and others, and buy zero-excess cover so a windscreen chip on gravel doesn't become an argument.

> **Fuel.** The longest gaps without fuel are Haast to Makarora/Wānaka on Day 4 and Te Anau to Milford Sound and back on Day 8 (235 km with no reliable fuel on the road†). Fill up in Hokitika (Day 2), Haast (Day 4), Twizel (Day 5) and Te Anau the evening before Milford (Day 7). Total fuel use is about 150 to 170 litres for a compact SUV.

Weather window (early March)

Early March is late summer into early autumn, and one of the most settled times in the Southern Alps: long days (sunset around 20:00 to 20:30), fewer crowds than January, and the first autumn colour in Central Otago late in the month. Typical conditions†: Queenstown and Wānaka have highs around 19 to 22°C and lows of 7 to 10°C. Tekapo and Aoraki/Mount Cook mornings can drop to 3 to 6°C. The West Coast is mild (highs about 18 to 20°C) but very wet: Franz Josef can get heavy rain on any day. That's why it gets two nights and why the heli flight has a fallback slot. Snow on the passes is unlikely in early March, but Arthur's Pass, Haast Pass and the Milford Road can all close briefly for rain, slips or rockfall. **Don't shift your dates:** they're already the sweet spot.

Money, payments, tipping

- Currency is the NZ dollar. Cards (including tap-to-pay) work almost everywhere, including small cafés and fuel stations. Expect card surcharges of 1 to 3% at some places. Carry about NZ$100 in cash for parking machines or the odd cash-only fruit stall.
- Tipping isn't expected in NZ. Round up for exceptional service if you like.
- Plugs are Type I, the same as Australia, so no adapter is needed.

Advisories and current intel (checked November 2026)

- **Hooker Valley Track (Aoraki):** the old swing bridge closed in April 2025. A new 189 m suspension bridge opened in mid-2026, and DOC is adding a "pause gate" to manage crowds on the first bridge. Expect queues at the bridges around midday.
- **Franz Josef Glacier/Kā Roimata o Hine Hukatere Walk:** river damage has shortened how far you can go up the valley. Stop at the barriers and check DOC alerts on the day. DOC trialled parking fees at glacier car parks (NZ$2.50 per half hour, NZ$20 a day) in 2025 to 2026. Expect something similar.
- **Haast Pass (SH6):** 2026 saw flooding and slip closures, and convoy-only windows at the Makarora to Hāwea end. **Check NZTA Journeys the night before Day 4 and again at breakfast.** There's no practical detour: going round

via Christchurch is far more than 500 km.

- **International visitor access charge:** the Conservation Amendment Bill (introduced May 2026) would let DOC charge non-resident international visitors (proposed NZ$20 to 40) at **Aoraki/Mount Cook** and **Milford Sound**, both on your route. It wasn't law when I checked. Look at DOC in February 2027, and if it applies, pay online in advance.
- **Te Anau Bird Sanctuary:** DOC scaled back operations in 2025 and its future is under review. Entry was still free and self-guided. Confirm before Day 7.
- **Blue Pools Track (Haast Pass):** reopened in May 2025 after two years of repairs. Check DOC status before Day 4.
- **Health:** no vaccinations are required for NZ. Australians are covered for medically necessary public hospital care in NZ under the reciprocal health agreement, and NZ's ACC covers accident treatment for visitors. Neither covers rental-car excess, cancellations or getting you home, so buy **travel insurance**.

Day 1 · Saturday 6 March 2027 · Land soft in Christchurch

Theme: arrival and orientation · Energy: Low · Drive: 17 km (optional) · Sunset 20:08 · Night: Novotel Christchurch Airport (Accor)

Weather note: Christchurch in early March is usually dry and warm (low to mid 20s°C). Check the MetService forecast for the West Coast tonight, because it decides tomorrow's pace.

14:30 to 15:45 · Arrival. Land, clear customs and biosecurity (allow 45 to 75 minutes), collect the rental car at the terminal. Before leaving the car park, the driver should check the tyres, find the wipers and lights, and pair a phone for navigation. **Travel:** 2-minute walk to the Novotel. Check in, drop bags, and move the car to hotel/airport parking.

16:10 to 17:50 · Optional, gentle: Willowbank Wildlife Reserve (10 km, about 15 minutes' drive).

- **Why it earns the slot:** it's a guaranteed first kiwi sighting in the nocturnal house, plus kea and takahē, all on flat paths. You'll see these birds again in the wild, so this sets up the trip without taxing anyone. Resellers list summer hours as 09:30 to 17:00 on weekdays and **until 18:00 on weekends (October to March)**, and the 6th is a Saturday. Walk-in is fine.
- **Lens fit:** wildlife, the gentle version.
- **Backup if tired or the flight is late:** skip it. Walk the Antarctic Walkway from the terminal and rest. The International Antarctic Centre (little blue penguins) closes around 16:30 per resellers, so it only works if you're through customs by 15:15.

18:10 onwards · Rest block. Back at the hotel by 18:10, long before sunset at 20:08. Buy breakfast supplies and water for tomorrow's long drive at the terminal shops.

Dinner: the Novotel's in-house restaurant† (walk-in). It's in the building, so there's no car and no taxi, and you're in bed early before a 07:15 start. I couldn't confirm the restaurant's current name and hours after the search allowance ran out, so check the hotel page.

Pacing check: no anchor today (arrival day), one rest block, no driving after 18:10. Tomorrow is the longest day of the trip, so **lights out by 22:00**.

Day 2 · Sunday 7 March · Over Arthur's Pass to Glacier Country

Theme: crossing the Alps · Energy: High · Drive: 429 km / about 6h10 at the wheel · Depart 07:15 (sunrise 07:15) · Arrive by 18:00 · Sunset at Franz Josef 20:16 · Night 1 of 2: Scenic Hotel Franz Josef Glacier

Weather note: if the West Coast forecast is torrential, swap the Hokitika Gorge for an earlier arrival. The gorge's turquoise colour disappears in flood anyway.

Morning

07:15 depart → SH73 west across the Canterbury Plains (86 km, about 1h15).

08:30 to 09:10 · Kura Tawhiti / Castle Hill. A 10-minute walk in among giant limestone boulders, with a 360° view of the Torlesse and Craigieburn ranges. A good first leg-stretch. **Backup:** the Lake Pearson / Moana Rua roadside stop 15 minutes further on.

09:55 to 11:00 · Anchor: Devil's Punchbowl Falls, Arthur's Pass village (53 km, about 45 minutes).

- **Why this one:** a 131 m waterfall at the end of an hour's return walk on a well-built track with steps. It's the best short walk in Arthur's Pass National Park and well inside your 2-hour limit.
- **Booking:** none. Car park in the village.
- **Lens fit:** mountains plus wildlife. Kea, the world's only alpine parrot, often hang around the village and its cafés. Don't feed them, and keep anything rubber away from them.

11:00 to 11:30 · Coffee: Arthur's Pass Store or **The Wobbly Kea**, across the road from each other. They're the only cafés in the village, both often have kea outside, and the Wobbly Kea does cooked breakfasts if 07:15 was too early to eat.

11:40 to 11:55 · Otira Viaduct Lookout (7 km). The engineering view down the Otira Gorge. Young kea gather here too.

Afternoon

13:10 to 13:50 · Lunch in Hokitika (92 km, about 1h15): **Fat Pipi Pizza†**, a long-running local favourite, or the cafés on Revell St. Fill up with fuel here.

14:25 to 15:25 · Hokitika Gorge (30 km, about 35 minutes inland). A short walk through rainforest to a swing bridge over impossibly milky-turquoise water. DOC lists about 45 minutes for the loop via the upper swing bridge; allow up to an hour. Parking is free but gets busy from November to April.

- **Cut rule:** if you leave Hokitika after 14:15, skip the gorge and drive straight to Franz Josef (134 km) to keep the 2-hour sunset buffer.

15:25 to 18:00 · Drive to Franz Josef (161 km, about 2h15 plus a 15-minute break at Ross or Harihari). The road narrows and the one-lane bridges begin.

Evening

18:00 · Check in, rest block. The car stays parked until tomorrow.

19:00 · Dinner: Canavans Restaurant & Moa Bar in your hotel. Dinner is 18:00 to 20:30 and the hotel says to **book ahead**. After a 6-hour driving day, eating where you sleep is the right call.

> **Energy backup:** if the driver is flagging at Arthur's Pass, drop Castle Hill and the gorge and arrive at Franz Josef around 16:00. Nothing irreplaceable is lost: you'll get bigger turquoise water at Blue Pools on Day 4.

Day 3 · Monday 8 March · Glacier Day

Theme: ice, reflections and kiwi · Energy: Medium-high · Drive: 56 km · Sunrise 07:26, sunset 20:14 · Night 2 of 2: Scenic Hotel Franz Josef Glacier

Weather note: on the West Coast, mornings are most often the clearest. Everything that needs a view is front-loaded, and the indoor kiwi centre is saved for the afternoon.

Morning

07:00 depart at first light → Lake Matheson (22 km, about 25 minutes, past Fox Glacier village).

07:25 to 08:55 · Anchor: Lake Matheson / Te Ara Kairaumati at sunrise

- **Why this one:** on a still morning the dark, tannin-stained lake mirrors Aoraki/Mount Cook and Mt Tasman. It's New Zealand's most famous reflection, and DOC says dawn on a windless day is best. The full circuit is 4.4 km and about 1h30. Short version: Jetty Lookout (45 minutes return) plus Reflection Island (5 minutes further) plus View of Views (15 minutes further, with steps).
- **Booking:** none, and parking is free. Bring insect repellent: DOC warns the sandflies are fierce.
- **Lens fit:** lakes plus mountains plus glacier country.

09:00 to 09:40 · Breakfast: Matheson Café† at the car park. Breakfast with the same mountain view through the windows.

10:30 to 11:15 · Optional anchor: glacier helicopter flight with snow landing, from Franz Josef village (drive back 25 minutes).

- **Why:** it's the only way to stand *on* the névé where Franz Josef and Fox are born without a long, strenuous guided walk, and the whole outing takes under an hour. It's a helicopter, not a boat. **Motion-sensitive traveller:** it's a smooth flight in good weather. Take a motion-sickness tablet beforehand if prone, or choose the shortest (20 to 25 minute, one-glacier) option.
- **Options checked in Nov 2026:** Heliservices "Spectacular Franz Josef" 20 minutes, from NZ$340 pp (rates change from 1 Oct 2026). Glacier Explorer, 25 minutes with a 10-minute landing, from about NZ$307. The Helicopter Line "Twin Glacier", 30 to 35 minutes, NZ$389 to 485. Snow landings are weather-dependent and the landing fee is refunded if you can't land.
- **Booking:** required. Book the **10:30 slot on Mon 8 Mar** on a refundable fare.
- **Backup if grounded:** operators often fly once the cloud lifts. Leave your name for an afternoon slot, and failing that, the **first flight on Tue 9 Mar (about 08:00)**. Day 4 still works if you leave Franz Josef by 09:30.

Afternoon

11:45 to 12:30 · Lunch: Alice May, 30 Cron St. Hearty, central and walkable.

12:45 to 14:15 · Franz Josef Glacier / Kā Roimata o Hine Hukatere Walk plus Sentinel Rock (4 km to the glacier car park, about 8 minutes). A rainforest and riverbed walk toward the terminal face, with a 20-minute side walk up Sentinel Rock for the classic framed view. Allow 1 to 1.5 hours. Follow the barriers: river damage has shortened the valley route. **Backup in heavy rain:** the short Peters Pool walk (15 minutes) from the same car park, then head straight to the Wildlife Centre.

14:45 to 16:15 · West Coast Wildlife Centre (village). Rowi, the world's rarest kiwi, plus tuatara, in a nocturnal house. Open 08:30 to 18:00 daily, and tickets are valid 48 hours. Add the **Backstage Pass** (40 minutes, very limited numbers, book ahead) to see the kiwi incubation and hatching rooms. That's your second kiwi of the trip, and the rarest.

16:30 to 18:30 · Rest block: Glacier Hot Pools† (rainforest hot pools in the village, about 5 minutes' walk) or simply a nap.

Evening

19:00 · Dinner: Blue Ice Restaurant & Bar at the south end of the village (+64 3 752 0707), for a change from the hotel. Or **SnakeBite Brewery** (28 Main Rd) for Asian-Kiwi fusion. Both are walkable. Book Blue Ice for a Monday in March.

Day 4 · Tuesday 9 March · Haast Pass to Wānaka

Theme: waterfalls and blue water · Energy: Medium · Drive: 286 km / about 3h50 · Depart 08:15 (09:30 if using the backup heli slot) · Arrive about 14:45 · Sunset 20:17 · Night: Wānaka (Edgewater or Wanaka Hotel)

> **Before you leave:** check NZTA Journeys for SH6 Haast Pass (closures and convoy windows happened in 2026). Fill the tank at Haast. If the pass is closed, stay a third night at Franz Josef. Closures are usually hours, not days. Then compress Day 5 by going straight to Tekapo via Wānaka and the Lindis Pass (Franz Josef → Tekapo is about 430 km, still legal).

Morning

08:15 depart → south on SH6 through rainforest and over long one-lane bridges.

10:00 to 10:15 · Knights Point Lookout (117 km, about 1h40). A clifftop lookout over the Tasman Sea from the road. It's a viewpoint, not a beach, and New Zealand fur seals are sometimes visible on the rocks below†.

10:35 · Haast: fuel and toilets (28 km). Then east up the Haast River into Mount Aspiring National Park.

11:20 to 11:50 · The Haast Pass waterfall run: Thunder Creek Falls (5 minutes' walk) and **Fantail Falls** (5 minutes), both signposted on the highway, plus the Gates of Haast bridge.

12:10 to 13:10 · Anchor: Blue Pools Track

- **Why this one:** two swing bridges over glacier-fed pools so clear and so blue that you can watch trout hanging in 5 m of water. It's 1.5 km each way through silver beech, about 1 hour return, and reopened by DOC in May 2025. The car park is off SH6 opposite Cameron Flat.
- **Lens fit:** lakes and rivers, mountain forest.
- **Backup if closed:** Roaring Billy Falls (25 minutes return, back near Haast) and a longer stop at Lake Wānaka lookouts.

Afternoon

13:20 to 14:00 · Lunch: Makarora Country Café†, the only café for many kilometres.

14:15 to 14:35 · The Neck lookout: the narrow neck of land between Lake Hāwea and Lake Wānaka. Two big lakes in one view.

14:45 · Arrive Wānaka, check in.

15:30 to 17:00 · Mt Iron Track (5 minutes' drive from town). About a 1.5-hour loop to a 360° summit view of Lake Wānaka, the Clutha River, the Cardrona valley and the Southern Alps. It's the best lookout in Wānaka within your limit. Roys Peak (5 to 6 hours) and Rocky Mountain/Diamond Lake (2.5 to 3 hours) are deliberately excluded. **Backup if wet:** the Wānaka lakefront path and Puzzling World.

Evening

17:30 · Rest block, then a lakeside stroll (path, not beach) past "That Wānaka Tree" at golden hour.

18:45 · Dinner: Kika. Wānaka's most consistently recommended restaurant: playful sharing plates, and the hazelnut cake is famous. It's small, so book. **Alternative:** Big Fig (takes dinner reservations) or Francesca's (Italian).

Day 5 · Wednesday 10 March · Aoraki/Mount Cook and the Mackenzie lakes

Theme: the highest mountain and the bluest lakes · Energy: High · Drive: 338 km / about 4h30 · Depart 07:35 (sunrise 07:32) · Arrive Tekapo 16:15 · Sunset 20:10 · Night: Lake Tekapo (Accor)

Morning

07:35 depart → SH8A/SH8 over the **Lindis Pass** (summit lookout at about 08:30, tussock ranges in early light) → Omarama → Twizel.

09:30 · Twizel: fuel and coffee in the town centre.

09:55 to 10:10 · Peter's Lookout, Lake Pūkaki. The classic postcard: milky-blue Pūkaki with Aoraki/Mount Cook at the far end.

10:50 to 12:20 · Anchor: Hooker Valley Track to the second swing bridge (White Horse Hill car park).

- **Why this one:** it's the most rewarding short walk in the country. Per DOC: Mueller Lookout and the first swing bridge are about 15 minutes in, the second swing bridge about 45 minutes. Turn around there for a **1.5-hour return**, versus 3 hours for the full track to Hooker Lake. Expect DOC's new "pause gate" queue at the first bridge around midday, which is why you arrive before 11:00.
- **Lens fit:** mountains, glacier river, and the Mueller Glacier moraine wall.
- **Backup if crowded or windy: Kea Point** (1 hour return from the same car park) for a face-on view of the Mueller Glacier and Mt Sefton.

Afternoon

12:30 to 13:15 · Lunch: The Old Mountaineers' Café†, Aoraki/Mount Cook village. Mountain memorabilia and big windows facing Aoraki. Alternative: the café at The Hermitage.

13:30 to 14:30 · Tasman Glacier View Track (8 km drive up the Tasman Valley Road, last part unsealed). About 40 minutes return† up steps to a moraine-top view over the Tasman Glacier's terminal lake, with icebergs if you're lucky. There's a short side track to the Blue Lakes. NZ's longest glacier, and the third glacier of your trip. *The boat trips on the terminal lake are deliberately excluded.*

14:30 to 16:15 · Drive to Tekapo (111 km). Stop at the **Lake Pūkaki visitor centre / Mt Cook Alpine Salmon shop** for salmon sashimi, which makes a good afternoon snack.

Evening

16:15 to 17:30 · Check in, rest block. Park the car: from here everything is on foot or by tour coach.

17:30 to 18:30 · Church of the Good Shepherd and the Tekapo lakefront (about a 9 to 15 minute walk from either Accor property). The 1935 stone church frames the turquoise lake through its altar window. Evening light is best.

18:45 · Dinner: Kohan, the village's Japanese restaurant (Fodor's Choice), famous for local salmon. **Alternative:** Rakinui at Peppers Bluewater (walkable if you stay there).

About 21:15 to 23:00 · Optional "delight" anchor: Dark Sky Project Summit Experience, Mount John University Observatory.

- **Why:** working research telescopes under one of the darkest skies on earth. Southern Cross, the Magellanic Clouds, and the Milky Way overhead in March. About 1h45, with a **coach from the Dark Sky Project building in the village**, so no driving after dark.
- **Booking:** required. NZ$219 per adult (price valid to 30 Sep 2026; 2027 price not yet published). Start time is set around sunset. It's cancelled with a full refund if it's cloudy. Dress for near-freezing temperatures on the summit.
- **Backup if clouded out:** an early night. Tomorrow starts at 09:00 anyway.

Day 6 · Thursday 11 March · Mount John, Lindis Pass and into Queenstown

Theme: lookouts all the way · Energy: Medium · Drive: 284 km / about 4h · Depart 09:00 · Arrive Queenstown 15:30 · Sunset 20:16 · Night: Novotel Queenstown Lakeside (Accor)

Why a 09:00 start: after last night's stargazing, the driver needs a proper sleep, and the Mount John road only opens at 09:00 anyway.

Morning

09:00 to 10:00 · Anchor: Mount John summit by daylight, breakfast at the Astro Café (10 km round trip).

- **Why:** a 360° view over Lakes Tekapo and Alexandrina and across the Mackenzie Basin to the Alps, from a glass-walled café. It's arguably the best café view in New Zealand. The road is open 09:00 to 16:00. The road toll per vehicle is NZ$8 to 14 (sources disagree), payable at the gate. The café serves 09:00 to 15:00.
- **Backup if the summit is closed for weather:** breakfast in the village, then the Tekapo lakefront walk to the footbridge.

10:00 to 13:05 · Drive Tekapo → Twizel → Omarama → Lindis Pass → Tarras → Cromwell (about 245 km). A 15-minute break at the Lindis Pass summit or at Cromwell's fruit stalls. Fill up in Cromwell.

Afternoon

13:05 · Kawarau Gorge: Roaring Meg lookout (gorge and rapids), then the historic **Kawarau Gorge Suspension Bridge**, where you can watch the world's first commercial bungy from the viewing deck.

13:45 to 14:45 · Lunch: Arrowtown. Provisions of Arrowtown† in a restored miner's cottage, then a stroll down Buckingham St and past the Chinese Settlement.

15:15 · Check in at the Novotel. Park the car for the rest of the day.

15:50 to 17:15 · Kiwi Park Queenstown (a 5 to 10 minute walk from the hotel). Kiwi Encounter sessions from October to April at 16:15 and 17:00, plus the conservation show. Kiwi, kea, tuatara and native birds. Last entry 17:00. Book the encounter slot. That's your third kiwi.

Evening

17:30 onwards · Anchor: Skyline Gondola to Bob's Peak and dinner at Stratosfare (next to Kiwi Park).

- **Why:** the defining Queenstown view: Lake Wakatipu, the Remarkables and Cecil and Walter Peaks from 450 m above town, with sunset at 20:16. The gondola and buffet dinner package was NZ$147 to 162 per adult in 2026 listings. It's a gondola, not a boat, and very smooth. If the motion-sensitive traveller hates it, both of you can walk down via the Tiki Trail (about 1 hour) in daylight.
- **Booking:** book a dinner time of about 18:30 so sunset happens over dessert.
- **Backup if windy (the gondola can pause): Fergburger** (order ahead online to skip the queue) eaten on the lakefront, then the Queenstown Gardens peninsula walk.

After sunset: walk back to the hotel (10 minutes). No driving.

Day 7 · Friday 12 March · Glenorchy Road, then Te Anau

Theme: Lake Wakatipu at first light, then the takahē · Energy: Medium · Drive: 264 km / about 3h35 · Depart 07:40 (sunrise 07:36) · Arrive Te Anau about 13:45 · Sunset 20:18 · Night: Distinction Luxmore, Te Anau

Morning

07:40 to 10:45 · Anchor: the Glenorchy Road (46 km each way).

- **Why:** it's often called one of the world's great short lake drives: 45 minutes hugging Lake Wakatipu toward the peaks at the head of the lake. Morning light hits the mountains and the water is often still.
- **Stops: Bennetts Bluff lookout** (08:00, the panorama), then **Glenorchy** (08:30 to 10:00): the red wharf shed on the lake edge (photos only, no boats), and the **Glenorchy Lagoon Walkway** boardwalks (30 to 60 minutes) with mountain reflections and waterbirds.
- **Breakfast: Glenorchy Café†** on the main street.
- **Backup if low cloud:** skip it and drive straight to Te Anau via Kingston, then spend longer at the Bird Sanctuary and Te Anau lakefront.

10:45 to 13:45 · Drive to Te Anau via Frankton, the Devil's Staircase along Lake Wakatipu, Kingston and Mossburn (171 km, about 2h20). Break at Kingston or Mossburn. Pick up a takeaway lunch in Queenstown on the way out.

Afternoon

13:45 · Check in (if your room isn't ready, leave your bags).

14:30 to 16:00 · Anchor: Punanga Manu o Te Anau / Te Anau Bird Sanctuary, along the lakefront path from the DOC visitor centre.

- **Why:** takahē, a flightless bird once thought extinct, which you'll almost certainly see here (breeding pairs raise chicks for release into the wild). Free, self-guided, open daylight hours, with donation boxes on site.
- **Status:** DOC reduced operations in 2025 and its future is under review. Confirm it's open the week before.
- **Backup:** the Te Anau lakefront walk toward the Control Gates. The Te Anau Glowworm Caves are *excluded* because they need a boat crossing.

16:00 · Fiordland National Park Visitor Centre (DOC): ask about the Milford Road (SH94) conditions and the Homer Tunnel. Then **fill the tank** and buy tomorrow's picnic and snacks, because there's nothing reliable on the road.

16:30 to 18:15 · Rest block.

Evening

18:30 · Dinner: Redcliff (12 Mokonui St). The local favourite for a sit-down dinner of wild game (Fiordland venison, hare) and lamb. Book ahead; it fills on March weekends. Early night: tomorrow starts at first light. **Alternative:** The Fat Duck (gastropub).

Option C variant (lighter end): if the driver is worn out by now, skip Te Anau and Milford entirely. Stay three nights at the Novotel Queenstown (Accor) and spend Days 7 to 8 on the Glenorchy road, Arrowtown, the Remarkables lookout and Kiwi Park. That saves about 400 km of driving and adds 2 Accor nights, at the cost of the Milford Road.

Day 8 · Saturday 13 March · The Milford Road

Theme: Fiordland's great alpine road · Energy: High · Drive: 407 km / about 5h35 · Depart 07:30 (first light, sunrise 07:41) · Back in Queenstown 17:15 · Sunset Queenstown 20:12 · Night: Novotel Queenstown Lakeside (Accor)

Weather note: Fiordland gets a lot of rain, and that's not a reason to cancel. In heavy rain hundreds of waterfalls appear on the cliffs, which some people prefer. Only cancel if NZTA closes SH94 (rockfall or avalanche risk), in which case use the backup below.

Morning (going in ahead of the Queenstown coach traffic)

07:30 depart Te Anau → north along Lake Te Anau into the Eglinton Valley.

08:15 · Mirror Lakes (about 58 km). A 5-minute boardwalk. Early and windless means the Earl Mountains reflected upside-down.

08:45 to 09:30 · Lake Gunn Nature Walk. A 45-minute loop through moss-draped red beech to the lake shore (a stony lake edge, not a beach).

09:50 to 10:30 · Lake Marian Falls: just the first section of the Lake Marian Track, about 20 minutes each way to the falls†. The full track to the lake (about 3 hours) is excluded.

10:45 · Monkey Creek (kea are often here) → **11:00 · Homer Tunnel.** A 1.2 km one-lane tunnel through the mountain with traffic lights; expect up to about 15 minutes' wait. The cirque of granite walls at the portal is the most dramatic roadside spot on the trip. Kea patrol the queue: don't feed them.

11:20 to 11:45 · The Chasm. A 20-minute loop to where the Cleddau River has carved sculpted holes through solid rock.

12:00 to 13:00 · Anchor: Milford Sound / Piopiotahi from the shore

- **Why:** Mitre Peak rising 1,692 m almost straight out of the fiord, with waterfalls pouring off the walls. The **Foreshore Walk** (about 20 to 30 minutes) gives you the classic view *without boarding anything*. Picnic lunch with the view.
- **Booking:** none. Pay for parking at the Milford car park. If the international visitor access charge is in force by March 2027, pay online beforehand.
- **Lens fit:** mountains, waterfalls, a glacier-carved fiord. **All cruises and kayaks are deliberately excluded.**

Afternoon

13:00 to 14:45 · Drive back to Te Anau (118 km), with any stops you skipped on the way in. Coffee and toilets in Te Anau, and a top-up of fuel.

15:00 to 17:15 · Te Anau → Queenstown (172 km, about 2h20 plus a break at Mossburn or Kingston). **Fill the tank at Frankton** on the way in, so tomorrow morning is just the drop-off.

17:15 · Check in, rest block, pack.

Evening

19:00 · Farewell dinner: Botswana Butchery on the lakefront: steaks and lake views, a short walk from the Novotel. Book about 4 weeks ahead for a Saturday in March. **Alternative: Rātā** (Josh Emett's fine dining, open from 17:00).

Backup if SH94 is closed: stay a second night in Te Anau if your booking allows, or return to Queenstown via the **Remarkables Road lookout†** and an afternoon at Arrowtown, while the road crews do their job. **Energy backup:** turn around at the Homer Tunnel. The Chasm and the Sound are spectacular, but the Eglinton Valley and the tunnel portal are 80% of the experience.

Day 9 · Sunday 14 March · Return the car and fly

Theme: no sightseeing (your rule) · Drive: 7 km · Flight ZQN 11:00

07:00 · Breakfast at the hotel. Final pack: liquids, and declare any food you're taking out.

07:45 · Leave the hotel → Queenstown Airport (7 km, about 10 to 15 minutes). The tank was filled last night at Frankton. Take photos of the fuel gauge and odometer at drop-off.

08:00 · Car returned, 3 hours before an international departure. Check in and relax. If the 11:00 flight turns out to be domestic, you can leave the hotel at 08:45 instead.

The shape of the trip:

- **Day 1:** land soft, first kiwi, early night.
- **Days 2 to 3:** cross the Alps and give the glaciers their due, with a weather buffer built in.
- **Day 4:** waterfalls and blue pools over the Haast, then a lake-town evening.
- **Day 5:** Aoraki at its closest, then Tekapo's lakes by day and stars by night.
- **Day 6:** lookout to lookout into Queenstown, then kiwi and the gondola sunset.
- **Days 7 to 8:** Lake Wakatipu at dawn, takahē, then the Milford Road.
- **Day 9:** fly home.

8. Deliberately left out, and why

Left out	Reason
Milford Sound / Doubtful Sound cruises, TSS Earnslaw, Shotover Jet, Tasman Glacier boat, Te Anau Glowworm Caves	All involve a boat or ferry.
Kaikōura whale watching and Abel Tasman	Boat-based, coastal, and off this route.
Hokitika Beach, Ship Creek beach, Gillespies Beach, Bruce Bay	Beaches. Knights Point gives the coast view from a clifftop instead.
Roys Peak, full Hooker Valley, Key Summit, Rob Roy Glacier, Lake Marian (full), Diamond Lake/Rocky Mountain	Each is over 2 hours. Shorter sections or alternatives are used instead.
Glacier heli-hikes (3+ hours)	Too long on foot. The scenic flight with snow landing covers the "on the ice" moment.
Christchurch city sightseeing	Arrival day is kept light. Wildlife at Willowbank is a better fit for you than the city.

9. Reservations tracker

These are the items that need action before the trip, sorted by when each one expires. Anything still "Not booked" at trip start either gets skipped or replaced with the listed backup. I have booked nothing. Every action is yours.

#	What	Why in advance	Book by	Where	Status	Notes
1	Travel insurance (both)	Covers anything you prepay from now on, and rental excess	**Fri 20 Nov 2026**	Your insurer	□ Not booked	Check it covers helicopter flights and rental-car excess.
2	One-way rental car CHC → ZQN, pick up Sat 6 Mar after 15:00, return Sun 14 Mar 08:00	Early March is busy; one-way fees and stock vary	**Mon 30 Nov 2026**	Compare GO Rentals, Europcar, Avis/Budget and others	□ Not booked	Zero-excess cover. One named driver only. Physical licence.
3	All 8 hotel nights (section 5)	Twin rooms within NZ$300 run out first in Queenstown, Tekapo and Te Anau	**Mon 30 Nov 2026**	all.accor.com (N1, N5, N6, N8); hotel sites for the others	□ Not booked	Free-cancellation rates. ALL number on every Accor booking. "Two separate beds" in the notes.
4	Passport validity check	Time to renew if needed	**Wed 9 Dec 2026**	passports.gov.au	□	
5	Glacier helicopter flight with snow landing, Mon 8 Mar 10:30	Morning slots in March fill first	**Fri 5 Feb 2027**	Operator sites (Heliservices, Glacier Helicopters, The Helicopter Line) or bookme.co.nz	□ Not booked	Refundable if weather cancels. Note the backup slot, Tue 9 Mar about 08:00.
6	Dark Sky Project Summit Experience, Wed 10 Mar (evening)	Limited coach seats; book-ahead discount	**Wed 10 Feb 2027**	darkskyproject.co.nz	□ Not booked	Ages 10+. Full refund if cloudy. Check the 2027 price.
7	Botswana Butchery, Queenstown, Sat 13 Mar 19:00	Saturday in March	**Sat 13 Feb 2027**	Restaurant website	□	Backup: Rātā.
8	Skyline Gondola and Stratosfare dinner, Thu 11 Mar about 18:30	Sunset tables go first	**Thu 25 Feb 2027**	skyline.co.nz (Queenstown)	□	The gondola can pause in high wind.
9	West Coast Wildlife Centre plus Backstage Pass, Mon 8 Mar 14:45	Backstage tour has very limited numbers	**Mon 22 Feb 2027**	Centre website or bookme.co.nz	□	Ticket valid 48 hours.
10	Canavans (Sun 7 Mar 19:00) and Blue Ice (Mon 8 Mar 19:00), Franz Josef	Small village, few restaurants	**Mon 22 Feb 2027**	Hotel / restaurant	□	
11	Kika, Wānaka, Tue 9 Mar 18:45	Small and popular	**Tue 23 Feb 2027**	Restaurant website	□	If no bookings are taken, arrive by 17:30.

12	Kohan, Tekapo, Wed 10 Mar 18:45	Before the stargazing tour	**Wed 24 Feb 2027**	Restaurant	□	
13	Redcliff, Te Anau, Fri 12 Mar 18:30	Fills on March weekends	**Fri 26 Feb 2027**	Restaurant	□	Backup: The Fat Duck.
14	International visitor access charge (Aoraki, Milford)	May be law by then	**Check Mon 1 Mar 2027**	doc.govt.nz	⚠ Watch	Proposed NZ$20 to 40 per person per site.
15	Kiwi Park Queenstown, Kiwi Encounter, Thu 11 Mar 16:15	Timed sessions	**Thu 4 Mar 2027**	Kiwi Park website or bookme.co.nz	□	Last entry 17:00.
16	NZ Traveller Declaration (both)	Mandatory for entry	**Fri 5 Mar 2027** (within 24 h of the flight)	travellerdeclaration.govt.nz	□	Free on the official site. Avoid paid look-alike sites.
17	Mount John road toll, Astro Café	None	On the day	Gate	No booking	Cash or EFTPOS. Road open 09:00 to 16:00.
18	Willowbank, Lake Matheson, Hokitika Gorge, Blue Pools, Hooker Valley, Tasman Glacier View, Te Anau Bird Sanctuary, Milford Road stops	None	n/a	DOC alerts the day before	No booking	Parking fees at some DOC car parks.

Categories checked with nothing to book: timed-entry museums (none on route), train or transit passes (n/a, self-drive), visas (none for Australian citizens), vaccinations (none required).

10. Packing list (two people, 8 nights, early March)

Layer 1: travel-day outfit

□ Comfortable trousers, T-shirt, fleece. The plane is cold and the Christchurch afternoon is warm.

□ Walking shoes, worn on the plane (saves bag space)

Layer 2: daily wear (cool mornings, warm afternoons, wet West Coast)

□ 4 quick-dry tops each (laundry at a motel or hotel around Day 5)

□ 2 pairs of walking trousers or hiking pants each, plus 1 pair of shorts

□ 1 warm mid-layer each (fleece or light down). Tekapo and Mt Cook mornings are 3 to 6°C.

□ 1 **waterproof shell** each. Essential: Franz Josef and Milford are among the wettest places in NZ.

□ Thermal top for the stargazing night (summit near 0°C)

□ Warm hat (beanie), light gloves, sun hat

Layer 3: activity wear

□ Small daypack each, with rain cover

□ Sunglasses: essential for the snow landing and Lake Pūkaki glare

□ Collapsible water bottles

Layer 4: footwear

□ Broken-in trail shoes or light boots, waterproof if possible. **Clean them before packing** (NZ biosecurity).

□ Sandals or slides for hotels and the hot pools. Keep them away from kea!

Layer 5: tech and documents

□ Passports (plus photocopies and a cloud copy)

□ **Physical** Australian driving licence (the driver)

□ Two cards on different networks. About NZ$100 cash.

□ Phones, chargers, **car USB-C charger** and a vent phone mount

□ Power bank (long drives with no coverage drain batteries)

□ Offline maps downloaded (see prep). No mobile coverage on large stretches of SH6 and SH94.

□ Camera and spare battery. A polariser helps for lake colour.

□ No plug adapter needed from Australia (Type I)

Layer 6: health

□ **Insect repellent** (picaridin or DEET): the West Coast and Fiordland sandflies are serious

□ **Motion-sickness tablets**, for the helicopter, gondola and winding roads (Milford, Haast)

□ SPF 50 sunscreen and SPF lip balm: NZ UV is very strong even when it's cool

□ Prescriptions plus 2 days' extra. Basic first-aid and blister kit. Antihistamine.

Layer 7: trip-specific smalls

□ Small cool bag for picnic lunches (Milford Day 8)

□ Reusable shopping bag (NZ supermarkets charge for bags)

□ Microfibre cloth for the windscreen and camera

□ Earplugs and eye mask: early sunrise starts, light hotels

□ Swimwear for the Glacier Hot Pools

11. Prep checklist: countdown to Saturday 6 March 2027

When	Do this
Now to 30 Nov 2026	□ Buy travel insurance (both of you) □ Book the rental car (one-way, zero excess) □ Book all 8 hotel nights on flexible rates, ALL number on the Accor ones □ Check both passports' expiry dates □ Confirm both of you are Australian citizens. If not, apply for the NZeTA (and IVL) now.
By 5 Feb 2027 (30 days out)	□ Book the heli flight (Mon 8 Mar) and Dark Sky tour (Wed 10 Mar) □ Driver: check the licence is current and physical. Note how long it has been held (some companies need 12+ months). □ Check for a no-foreign-fee card; add frequent-flyer and ALL numbers to all bookings □ Book Botswana Butchery (by 13 Feb) □ Recheck hotel prices: if a better ALL rate appears, rebook (flexible rate)
By 20 Feb 2027 (14 days out)	□ Book the remaining restaurants, Skyline/Stratosfare, the Wildlife Centre backstage pass and the Kiwi Encounter □ Set up roaming or an NZ eSIM (Australian carriers sell NZ roaming packs) □ Download offline Google Maps for the whole South Island route, plus the NZTA Journeys and MetService apps □ Print the emergency contacts page (section 12) and fill in hotel phone numbers and the insurance policy □ Check DOC alerts: Hooker Valley, Franz Josef valley walk, Blue Pools, Te Anau Bird Sanctuary
By 27 Feb 2027 (7 days out)	□ Look at the 7-day forecast: if Day 3 looks wet, keep the heli booking but plan the morning-of call with the operator □ Check DOC for the international visitor access charge (Aoraki, Milford) □ Cloud and paper copies of passports, licence, insurance, bookings □ Clean all hiking footwear (biosecurity) □ Mail hold, house or pet sitter if needed
Fri 5 Mar 2027 (24 hours out)	□ Complete the **NZ Traveller Declaration** (both) on the official site □ Web check-in for the flight to Christchurch □ Charge everything; motion tablets and repellent in your carry-on
Sat 6 Mar 2027 (day of)	□ Hotel addresses saved offline □ Cards, licence and passport on your person, not in checked bags □ Declare food at the NZ border

12. Emergency contacts (print this page and keep it with your passport)

Who	Contact
Police, fire, ambulance (NZ)	**111**. Mobile coverage is patchy on SH6 Haast and SH94 Milford; use the roadside emergency phones where present.
Healthline (free 24/7 health advice, NZ)	0800 611 116†
Road conditions	NZTA Journeys: journeys.nzta.govt.nz (or the app)
Australian High Commission, Wellington (covers NZ south of Lake Taupō, i.e. your whole route)	72–76 Hobson Street, Thorndon, Wellington 6011 · +64 4 473 6411 · Mon to Fri 09:00 to 12:30 and 13:00 to 16:00
24-hour Consular Emergency Centre (DFAT)	+61 2 6261 3305
Travel insurer, 24-hour emergency line and policy no.	_____
Rental car roadside assistance and booking ref.	_____
Card lost or stolen lines (both cards)	_____
Home contact who has this itinerary	_____
Peppers Bluewater Resort, Tekapo (if used)	+64 3 680 7000 · bluewater@peppers.co.nz
Westland Tai Poutini NP Visitor Centre (Franz Josef DOC)	+64 3 752 0360 · westlandnpvc@doc.govt.nz
Dark Sky Project (Tekapo)	0800 327 5759
Blue Ice Restaurant, Franz Josef	+64 3 752 0707
Hotels N1 to N8: add numbers from your confirmations	N1 _____ N2–3 _____ N4 _____ N5 _____ N6/N8 _____ N7 _____

If there's a crash or breakdown: get off the road completely. One-lane bridges and blind corners are the danger. Hazard lights on, call 111 if anyone is hurt, then the rental company's roadside line. **If a road is closed:** don't push on. Every day in this plan has a stated fallback, and the 500 km and daylight rules still apply.

13. Budget summary (estimates, NZ$, for two people)

Item	Basis	Estimate (NZ$)
Hotels, 8 nights	Average about NZ$260 a night (cap NZ$300): Franz Josef cheaper, Queenstown and Te Anau near the cap	2,100
Rental car, 9 days, one-way, zero-excess cover	About NZ$110 to 160 a day all-in, plus a one-way fee of 0 to 300. Recheck when you book.	1,500
Fuel	About 2,090 km at 7.5 L/100 km ≈ 160 L × about NZ$2.80/L†	450
Parking and tolls	Airport and DOC car parks, Mt John toll, Milford parking	100
Glacier helicopter flight (optional)	2 × about NZ$340 to 485	850
Dark Sky Summit Experience (optional)	2 × about NZ$219+ (2026 price)	450
Wildlife: Willowbank, WC Wildlife Centre plus backstage, Kiwi Park	2 × (about 40 + 70 + 55)	330
Skyline Gondola plus Stratosfare dinner	2 × about NZ$150 to 162	320
Glacier Hot Pools	2 × about NZ$35†	70
Possible international visitor access charge	2 people × 2 sites × up to NZ$40 (if in force)	160
Food and drink (excluding Stratosfare)	About NZ$110 per person per day; two restaurant dinners at the top end	1,900
Subtotal		**8,230**
Buffer, 12% (price rises from 2026 listings, a weather rebooking, an extra night if a pass closes)		990
Total on the ground (excluding flights and insurance)		**about 9,220 (≈ 4,610 per person)**

Without the two optional splurges (heli and stargazing) the total drops by about NZ$1,300. Exchange rates aren't included: check AUD/NZD when you book. Prices are 2026 snapshots from the listed sources and will move.

Revision offer

One round of revisions is included. The most likely adjustments are: (1) switching to Option C if one driver for 2,090 km feels like too much; (2) moving Tekapo to Peppers Bluewater if you'll accept a sofa bed for the Accor night; (3) dropping the helicopter or stargazing to lower the cost. Tell me which and I'll re-issue the plan.

14. Sources (checked 9 November 2026)

Hotels: all.accor.com pages for Novotel Christchurch Airport (A542), Peppers Bluewater Resort (B3Q7), Mantra Lake Tekapo (B3M7), Novotel Queenstown Lakeside, and the Accor Lake Tekapo and Queenstown destination pages; newzealand.com business listings (Peppers Bluewater, Mantra Lake Tekapo price ranges); Expedia, Hotels.com and HotelsCombined snapshots for Scenic Hotel Franz Josef Glacier, Distinction Luxmore, Edgewater, Wanaka Hotel and The Godley Hotel; milesopedia.com (Peppers brand list); travelmole.com (Oakridge Wānaka history); scenichotelgroup.co.nz (Canavans Restaurant hours).
Walks and parks: doc.govt.nz pages for Lake Matheson, Hooker Valley Track, Hokitika Gorge, Franz Josef Glacier walk, the Te Anau Bird Sanctuary, the Hooker Valley bridge media releases (2025 to 2026) and the Aoraki newsletter (Sep 2026); mackenzienz.com (Aoraki short walks); 1news.co.nz and rnz.co.nz (Blue Pools reopening, May 2025); freewalks.nz.
Roads: journeys.nzta.govt.nz traffic bulletins (SH6 Haast closures 2026; SH94 works Jan 2026); nzta.govt.nz Homer Tunnel project pages. Distances: OpenStreetMap / OSRM routing (router.project-osrm.org). Sunrise and sunset: calculated with the NOAA solar algorithm for each town (NZDT, UTC+13).
Activities: darkskyproject.co.nz (Summit Experience, Astro Café, Mt John road hours); bookme.co.nz, airnewzealand.co.nz activity deals and rezdy (glacier flights, West Coast Wildlife Centre, Willowbank, Kiwi Park, International Antarctic Centre); newzealand.com listings (Kiwi Park hours, West Coast Wildlife Centre hours, Skyline); queenstown.skyline.co.nz.
Entry and safety: immigration.govt.nz (NZeTA, Australian citizens; NZTD); newzealand.embassy.gov.au and dfat.gov.au (Australian High Commission); doc.govt.nz (international visitor access charges consultation, 2026); thespinoff.co.nz (Conservation Amendment Bill, May 2026); rental-company licence pages (vroomvroomvroom.com.au, enterpriserentacar.co.nz, airportrentals.com.au); gorentals.co.nz (one-way fees).
Restaurants: fodors.com, powderhounds.com, neatplaces.co.nz (Tekapo); theurbanlist.com, myqueenstowndiary.com (Wānaka, Te Anau); glaciercountry.co.nz, frommers.com (Franz Josef); manofmany.com, theurbanlist.com (Queenstown); chrisandwrensworld.com, fodors.com (Arthur's Pass).
† = named from planner knowledge after the live-search allowance for this session ran out; verify hours and details before relying on them.